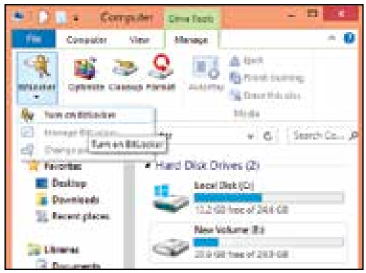
there's no shortage of tips and tricks (such as disabling the task manager or the registry editor itself) on how to effectively utilise it. All keys and hives of registry are also controlled using permissions that resemble the NTFS permission set. Registry is (mostly) built by files located in Windows\System32\config folder in your installation drive. If you change the permissions on the right hive, you'd be able to see your encrypted password, your password hint... everything. Back that hive/key up and you've created another way to recover your password!

BitLocker



You can turn on BitLocker right from the File Explorer

Introduced in Windows Vista and enhanced in subsequent releases, BitLocker is a full-disk-encryption method which encrypts an entire volume (this could be an entire disk or a primary or logical partition) using AES 128 bit encryption. Though the algorithm is well known by the world, its implementation in BitLocker is closed and has probably been altered. BitLocker can be used to encrypt any drive attached to Windows Vista. However with Windows 7, BitLocker was available to be used on external drives as well.

Given that the hardware has a TPM (Trusted Platform Module) chip, it can also encrypt the Windows installation drive. The OS drive encryption requires an additional volume formatted in NTFS with a size of 100 MB which is left unencrypted (there's your answer to why Windows 7 Ultimate creates that apparently useless partition of 100 MB when installing). This volume is used to store the files responsible for loading Windows. This is similar to Linux which can also have a separate '/boot' partition. However, if the files on the boot volume of Windows are found to be altered, BitLocker will refuse to load Windows! BitLocker is available in Enterprise and Ultimate editions of Windows Vista and Windows 7 as well as in Pro and Enterprise editions of Windows 8. You can find BitLocker in Control Panel.

Integrity Levels

Integrity Levels were introduced in Windows Vista to enhance the protection provided by Windows ACLs (Access Control Lists). Prior to Vista, any